METHODOLOGY HANDBOOK / VERSION 0.2

FALK INDEX

A transparent framework for describing how watches are actually created

The classification is the headline.
The provenance is the evidence.

TRANSPARENCY NOTE • This framework and reference dataset were developed in part with the assistance of AI. AI was used to help structure the methodology, compare edge cases, organize research and draft this handbook. The system is intended to be evidence-led and open to correction: individual claims and profiles should ultimately be traceable to public sources.

FALK is the name of the methodology, not a forced scoring acronym.

Version 0.2 replaces the earlier four-letter prototype with descriptive dimensions chosen for clarity and accuracy. It also removes the aggregate score: a FALK Profile is not a quality ranking.

SECTION 01

Why the FALK Index exists

Watch-industry labels often answer different questions while pretending to answer the same one. "Independent" may describe ownership, scale, creative culture or actual watchmaking. "Manufacture" may describe movement authorship, component production, assembly or simply a marketing position. "Microbrand" can place a catalog-based contract watch and a highly developed specialist-supplier project in the same bucket.

FALK separates those questions. It records where the intellectual and physical work occurs, how well that is documented, and only then assigns a plain-language production classification.

CORE PRINCIPLE • Provenance, not prestige. Outsourcing to a world-class specialist is not inherently inferior to making a component internally. Vertical integration is not synonymous with quality.

The model, not the logo

A company can use radically different production routes across its catalog or history. The primary unit of classification is therefore an exact model, reference, generation or clearly defined production route. Brand pages may summarize those records later, but should never overwrite them.

This is especially important for companies such as J.N. Shapiro, Tudor, anOrdain and Christopher Ward, where different watches can occupy meaningfully different manufacturing positions.

SECTION 02

Foundational rules

Rule	Meaning
Model first	Score an exact reference, generation or production route whenever possible.
Unknown is not zero	If reliable evidence is unavailable, use U. Non-disclosure is not proof of outsourcing.
No double counting	Each activity belongs primarily to one dimension. Where an operation affects two dimensions, the rationale must distinguish the physical manufacture from the craft or engineering contribution.
Internal means internal	External artisan work enriches the watch's provenance but does not become the brand's internal craft score.
Authorship is not manufacture	A proprietary caliber can be designed for a brand and physically produced by partners. Architecture/development credit is separate from manufacturing credit.
Group capability is disclosed	A sister company or group-owned supplier is recorded as in-group rather than silently treated as brand-internal.
Marketing terms are claims	'In-house', 'manufacture', 'handmade' and 'Swiss Made' are starting points for research, not self-proving classifications.
Time matters	Suppliers and production routes change. Records should carry production dates or generations when relevant.
Classification comes last	Do not choose 'microbrand', 'atelier' or 'manufacture' first and then bend the profile to fit.

SECTION 03

The FALK Profile

Seven descriptive dimensions summarize a production route. Each dimension is scored 0-5, or U when evidence is insufficient. They are never added together.

MA Movement Architecture

Who is responsible for the caliber's mechanical architecture and engineering?

0	Stock third-party caliber
1	Cosmetic/custom specification
2	Meaningful modification/module
3	Heavily re-engineered architecture
4	Proprietary caliber developed for brand; substantial external engineering possible
5	Deep proprietary caliber engineering substantially mastered internally

MM Movement Manufacturing

How much of the movement is physically manufactured by the brand or atelier?

0	Complete movement external
1	Minor/simple parts internal
2	Some meaningful components internal
3	Significant portion internal
4	Most major components internal
5	Exceptional integration including difficult regulating/escapement components or equivalent depth

EX Exterior Manufacturing

How much of the case, bracelet, crown and other exterior hardware is physically made internally?

0	Exterior external
1	Minor/simple exterior parts internal
2	One important component family internal
3	Several principal families internal
4	Most major exterior hardware internal
5	Exceptional vertical exterior manufacture

DH Dial & Hands Manufacturing

How much of dial and hand production is performed internally?

0	Dial and hands external
1	Minor internal operations
2	One meaningful production stage internal
3	Substantial dial or hand manufacture
4	Both major dial and hand processes deeply internal
5	Defining, highly integrated dial/hand manufacture

CF Craft & Finishing

What meaningful artisanal transformation is physically performed inside the brand or atelier?

0	No documented internal artisanal craft
1	Limited manual decorative operations
2	Regular skilled handwork, not central
3	Substantial hand finishing/craft
4	Advanced métiers d'art or haute-horlogerie finishing is a major capability
5	Exceptional master-level craft fundamentally defining the product

WE Watchmaking Execution

What watchmaking occurs after the components exist?

0	Complete/nearly complete watches supplied externally
1	Final QC, strap fitting, limited casing/adjustment
2	Complete casing/assembly and basic regulation
3	Movement preparation/adjustment plus full assembly, regulation and testing
4	Deep movement assembly, complication work and adjustment
5	End-to-end construction, assembly, adjustment and complex watchmaking

PD Product Development

How much original product design, supplier direction and technical development belongs to the brand?

0	Private-label/catalog product
1	Primarily cosmetic specification
2	Original design around conventional supplier architecture
3	Bespoke components and substantial supplier-directed development
4	Extensive original technical development/proprietary systems
5	Deep original engineering or invention defining the watch

SECTION 04

Provenance fields

The seven dimensions are the summary. The provenance record is the substance. A future FALK website should expose the evidence underneath every profile.

Field	What should be recorded
Movement architecture	Stock / modified / proprietary; designer or engineering partner; caliber lineage.
Movement manufacture	Who cuts plates, bridges, wheels, pinions, escapement parts, hairspring and other components.
Case / exterior	Case, crown, bracelet, clasp and crystal suppliers or internal processes.
Dial / hands	Who manufactures blanks, guilloché, enamel, printing, indices, hands, heat treatment and related processes.
Craft / finishing	Which hand processes are internal, external or mixed; named artisan where known.
Assembly / regulation	Who assembles the movement/watch, regulates, tests and performs after-sales watchmaking.
Development	Who designed the watch, engineered bespoke parts, developed complications or directed suppliers.
Relationship	Internal / in-group / external specialist / contract manufacturer / unknown.
Evidence	Source URL, exact claim, publication date, date checked and confidence.

Evidence confidence

A	Strong primary evidence for essentially every scored dimension.
B	Good primary evidence with limited gaps; credible specialist reporting fills some gaps.
C	Material gaps remain; useful but provisional.
D	Sparse or conflicting evidence; publish provenance notes, but avoid a definitive profile.

SECTION 05

FALK classifications

The classification is the human-readable layer. It is assigned after the profile and provenance review. These are production archetypes, not status tiers.

Classification	Working definition
Contract / Microbrand	Original brand/design contribution, but physical production is overwhelmingly external. Product development can still be meaningful.
Design-led Établisseur	Creates the watch by directing a network of suppliers. Internal fabrication may be low while development and movement authorship can be high.
Artisan Établisseur	Major specialist craft is present, but much or all of that craft is performed by external named partners.
Artisan Atelier	A defining métier such as engraving, enameling, guilloché, dialmaking or hand finishing is physically performed internally.
Watchmaking Atelier	Meaningful internal assembly, regulation, modification and watchmaking without broad movement fabrication.
Independent Manufacture	Proprietary technical authorship plus meaningful internal movement/component manufacture.
Integrated Manufacture	Broad internal production across movement and major exterior components, with deep internal watchmaking execution.
Independent Watchmaker	A human descriptor: an identifiable watchmaker personally performs substantial watchmaking/craft on the watches. It is not automatically generated by thresholds.
Industrial Manufacture	Scaled institutional production with meaningful internal movement/watch manufacturing. Ownership can be independent or group-based.

Ownership and scale are separate metadata. Patek Philippe can be independently owned and still operate as an industrial/integrated manufacture. Fleming can be independent without Thomas Fleming personally being a watchmaker.

SECTION 06

How to use the FALK Index

1	Identify the exact watch. Record reference, generation and production period.
2	Build the provenance sheet. Research movement, case/exterior, dial/hands, craft, assembly/regulation and development separately.
3	Prefer primary evidence. Manufacturer/workshop documentation and named supplier disclosures come first. Technical interviews and specialist references such as Caliber Corner are useful secondary corroboration.
4	Score each dimension independently. Use U rather than guessing. Explain borderline scores.
5	Assign confidence. Confidence describes the evidence, not confidence in the brand.
6	Assign the classification last. The archetype summarizes the profile; it does not control it.
7	Preserve the audit trail. Every future change should carry a source, rationale, editor and date.

Recommended public record

J.N. Shapiro — Resurgence
FALK Profile: MA5 · MM5 · EX5 · DH5 · CF5 · WE5 · PD5
Classification: Integrated Independent Manufacture / Independent Watchmaker
Confidence: A

On a future website, each dimension would expand to show the evidence and source links that justify it.

SECTION 07

Edge cases the framework must handle

Case	Why it matters
J.N. Shapiro — Infinity vs. Resurgence	The same brand can occupy very different manufacturing positions. The Infinity concentrates Shapiro's contribution heavily in dialmaking and craft around externally sourced major components, while the Resurgence represents radically deeper internal fabrication.
Fleming	High-end external manufacture is not the same thing as ordinary contract production. A project can have low MM/EX/DH while scoring very highly in PD and MA because the brand commissions bespoke engineering and coordinates elite specialists.
Artur Akmaev	An artist/watchmaker can have extraordinary internal craft while using an external movement and case. CF therefore remains independent from MM and EX.
AWAKE vs. anOrdain	A watch can contain major artisanal work without the brand itself performing it. External artisan work belongs in provenance and may support PD, but it does not automatically create internal CF or DH points.
Czapek	'Designed in-house, made by partners' is exactly the kind of statement FALK should preserve. It can produce high MA/PD with lower MM instead of forcing the movement into a binary in-house/not-in-house box.

SECTION 08

Reference dataset

A 56-record stress test of the methodology. These are provisional editorial profiles, not immutable verdicts or a leaderboard. Profile order: MA / MM / EX / DH / CF / WE / PD.

Brand	Model / route	Profile	Classification	Conf.
J.N. Shapiro	Infinity Series	0/0/0/5/5/3/3	Artisan Atelier	B
J.N. Shapiro	Resurgence	5/5/5/5/5/5/5	Integrated Independent Manufacture	A
Artur Akmaev	Koi / Tide	0/0/0/0/5/3/3	Artisan Atelier	A
anOrdain	Model 1 Fumé	0/0/0/5/4/3/3	Artisan / Watchmaking Atelier	A
AWAKE	Sơn Mài / Guilloché Main	0/0/0/0/0/0/4	Artisan Établisseur	A
Fleming	Series 1	4/0/0/0/0/1/5	Design-led Établisseur	B
Ophion	OPH 786 Vélos	2/0/0/0/0/0/3	Design-led Établisseur	A
Atelier Wen	Perception V3	0/0/0/0/0/2/4	Artisan Établisseur	A
Sartory Billard	SB05	1/0/0/2/3/3/4	Artisan Atelier / Établisseur	B
Laine	P37	4/2/1/2/5/4/4	Independent Watchmaking Atelier	B
Kudoke	Kudoke 2	4/2/1/2/5/5/4	Independent Watchmaker	A
Habring²	Erwin / A11 family	5/2/1/1/3/5/5	Independent Manufacture / Networked Fabrication	A
Philippe Dufour	Simplicity	5/4/2/2/5/5/5	Independent Watchmaker	A
Roger W. Smith	Series 2	5/5/5/5/5/5/5	Integrated Independent Watchmaker	A

continued

REFERENCE DATASET / CONTINUED

Brand	Model / route	Profile	Classification	Conf.
Rexhep Rexhepi	Chronomètre Contemporain	5/3/2/2/5/5/5	Independent Watchmaker / Manufacture	B
Akrivia	AK-06	5/3/2/2/5/5/5	Independent Watchmaker / Manufacture	A
F.P. Journe	Chronomètre Souverain	5/4/3/3/5/5/5	Integrated Independent Manufacture	B
H. Moser & Cie.	Endeavour Centre Seconds	5/5/3/3/4/5/5	Integrated Independent Manufacture	A
MB&F	LM Sequential EVO	5/2/1/1/4/5/5	Collaborative Independent Manufacture	A
De Bethune	DB25 / manufacture caliber	5/4/3/3/5/5/5	Integrated Independent Manufacture	A
Laurent Ferrier	Classic Micro-Rotor	5/3/2/2/5/5/5	Independent Manufacture	B
Czapek	Antarctique SXH5	4/1/0/0/3/4/5	Établisseur / Manufacture Hybrid	A
NOMOS Glashütte	Tangente neomatik	5/4/3/3/2/5/5	Integrated Manufacture	A
Moritz Grossmann	Benu	5/4/3/3/5/5/5	Integrated Manufacture	A
A. Lange & Söhne	Lange 1	5/4/3/3/5/5/5	Integrated Haute Manufacture	A
Jaeger-LeCoultre	Reverso Tribute	5/5/4/4/4/5/5	Integrated Industrial Manufacture	A
Grand Seiko	Spring Drive 9R (Shinshu)	5/5/5/5/4/5/5	Integrated Industrial Manufacture	A
Rolex	Submariner 124060	5/5/5/5/2/5/5	Integrated Industrial Manufacture	A

continued

REFERENCE DATASET / CONTINUED

Brand	Model / route	Profile	Classification	Conf.
Tudor	Black Bay 58 / MT5402	4/3/2/2/1/5/4	Industrial Manufacture / In-group Network	A
Breitling	Chronomat B01	5/3/2/2/2/5/5	Industrial Manufacture	A
Cartier	Santos / 1847 MC	4/3/3/3/2/5/4	Industrial Manufacture	B
Vacheron Constantin	Overseas / manufacture caliber	5/4/3/3/5/5/5	Integrated Haute Manufacture	B
Audemars Piguet	Royal Oak 16202	5/4/3/3/5/5/5	Integrated Haute Manufacture	B
Omega	Speedmaster Moonwatch 3861	5/4/3/3/2/5/5	Integrated Industrial Manufacture	B
IWC	Ingenieur Automatic 40	4/3/2/2/2/5/4	Industrial Manufacture	B
Longines	Spirit Zulu Time	1/0/1/1/1/4/3	Industrial / In-group Supplier Model	B
Oris	Aquis Calibre 400	4/1/0/0/1/4/4	Independent Industrial / Proprietary Supplier Model	B
Christopher Ward	The Twelve	0/0/0/0/0/2/3	Design-led Brand / Contract Production	A
Christopher Ward	C1 Bel Canto	3/1/0/0/1/3/5	Technical Atelier / Supplier Hybrid	A
MING	37.02 Minimalist	0/0/0/0/0/1/4	Design-led Établisseur	A
Baltic	Aquascaphe	0/0/0/0/0/3/2	Microbrand with Internal Assembly	A
Studio Underd0g	01SERIES Gen3	0/0/0/0/0/3/3	Microbrand with Internal Assembly	A

continued

REFERENCE DATASET / CONTINUED

Brand	Model / route	Profile	Classification	Conf.
Farer	Three-hand automatic	0/0/0/0/0/1/3	Design-led Microbrand	A
Serica	5303 COSC	0/0/0/0/0/1/3	Design-led Microbrand	A
Unimatic	Modello Uno Sellita	0/0/0/0/0/1/3	Design-led Microbrand	A
ZRC	MN64 Metal	1/1/1/1/0/2/3	Industrial / Design-led Specialist	B
Lesablier	Chronosport	0/0/0/0/0/0/2	Contract / Microbrand	A
Lesablier	Travelgraph	0/0/0/0/0/0/2	Contract / Microbrand	A
Kurono Tokyo	Chronograph / Miyota-based lines	0/0/0/0/1/1/4	Designer-led Établisseur	C
Studio Underd0g	03SERIES	0/0/0/0/0/3/3	Microbrand with Internal Assembly	B
Atelier Wen	Perception Mù (SL1588A)	0/0/0/0/0/2/4	Artisan Établisseur	A
anOrdain	Model 2 Porcelain	0/0/0/5/4/3/3	Artisan / Watchmaking Atelier	A
anOrdain	Model 1 Fabrik	0/0/0/1/0/3/3	Watchmaking Atelier	B
Habring²	Five Minute Repeater	5/2/1/1/3/5/5	Independent Manufacture / Supplier Network	B
Tudor	Black Bay Chrono / MT5813	3/2/2/2/1/5/4	Industrial Manufacture / Shared Architecture	B
Grand Seiko	9F Quartz (Shinshu)	5/5/5/5/3/5/5	Integrated Industrial Manufacture	A

SECTION 09

Toward an open, community-regulated database

The long-term value of FALK is not the PDF itself. It is an auditable evidence graph behind each model. The handbook can remain the stable methodology specification while a website or wiki becomes the living record.

Principle	Implementation
Canonical model pages	One page per model/reference/generation, with production years and revision history.
Dimension-level evidence	Every score has its own rationale, source links, date checked and editor.
Facts ≠ judgments	Store the factual claim separately from the editorial score it supports.
Source hierarchy	Primary manufacturer/workshop disclosures first; technical interviews and specialist sources such as Caliber Corner clearly labeled as secondary.
Visible disputes	Conflicting evidence remains visible rather than being silently overwritten.
Version control	Score changes require a source and change note; methodology changes require a version bump.
Open corrections	Brands, watchmakers and readers may submit evidence-based corrections.
Commercial independence	No paid placement, paid score improvement or hidden sponsor weighting.

Example evidence record

CLAIM • Movement architecture conceived by brand; physical production performed with external specialist partners.
DIMENSIONS • MA / MM / PD
SOURCE TYPE • Primary manufacturer statement
SOURCE • Direct URL
EXCERPT • Short supporting quotation
DATE CHECKED • YYYY-MM-DD
EDITOR NOTE • Why this evidence supports the assigned profile.

SECTION 10

Starting source set

This is a seed bibliography used to stress-test the framework, not yet a complete row-by-row source ledger. A future public database should move every source down to the exact model and dimension it supports.

Source	Starting point
J.N. Shapiro	jnshapirowatches.com/watches/
anOrdain	anordain.com/pages/watchmaking • anordain.com/pages/enamelling
Artur Akmaev	akmaev.com
AWAKE	awakewatches.com
MB&F	mbandf.com/people-spirit/the-friends
Rolex	rolex.com/watchmaking/a-unique-approach
Tudor	tudorwatch.com/.../tudor-manufacture-movement
Kenissi	kenissi.ch/History
Grand Seiko	grand-seiko.com/.../manufacture/shinshuwatchstudio
NOMOS	nomos-glashuette.com/en/watchmaking/production
Habring²	habring2.com/.../service/faqs
Roger W. Smith	rwsmithwatches.com/workshop
Philippe Dufour	philippedufour.ch/en/mes-creations/
Czapek	czapek.com/new-antarctique
Baltic	baltic-watches.com/en/about-us
Studio Underd0g	underd0g.com/pages/about-us
Atelier Wen	atelierwen.com/products/perception
Ophion	ophion-watches.com/oph-index
Moritz Grossmann	grossmann-uhren.com/manufacture/
A. Lange & Söhne	alange-soehne.com/.../manufacture-movements
Breitling	breitling.com/.../madebybreitling/
Caliber Corner	calibercorner.com

FALK Index v0.2 is an independent editorial framework. Profiles are provisional research judgments and should be revised when better evidence becomes available.